compliment to his wives, the daughters of the Rajahs of Hind,' noted Badauni, 'he had within the female apartments continued to offer the hom, which is a ceremony derived from sun-worship.' Now, continued Badauni, Akbar went one step further and prostrated himself in public before the fire as well as the sun. Akbar also began appearing in the diwan-e-aam with a tilak on the forehead and a rakhi on the wrist, tied by a Brahmin, as a blessing. Immediately all the elegant noblemen adopted the custom and it became de rigueur to wear a rakhi to court. Jahangir remembered this custom and wrote that 'the Hindu Amirs and others in imitation of them performed the ceremony of rakhi in adorning [Akbar], making strings of rubies and royal pearls and flowers jewelled with gems of great value and binding them on his auspicious arms'.

He 'prohibited the slaughter of cows and the eating of their flesh', bemoaned Badauni, 'because the Hindus devoutly worship them and esteem their dung as pure'. This restriction on eating beef was seen as a particular injunction against all Muslims and it was Badauni, once again, who also noted that since 'he had introduced a whole host of the daughters of eminent Hindu Rajahs into his haram, and they had influenced his mind against the eating of beef and garlic and onions, and association with people who wore beards—and such things he then avoided and still does avoid'. The Jesuits were clearly discomfited by all these new changes, for Acquaviva wrote a letter to the Provincial of Goa, confessing that 'the King keeps this Court in a great state of embarrassment with the novelties he introduces every day in it. For among other things,' he went on to write, 'he seems to pay much reverence to God's creatures such as the sun and the moon. And from Saturday evening to the end of Sunday he does not eat flesh-meat, and I am credibly informed that many heathens [Hindus] here do this.' A well-known quote of Akbar's also points to his gradual distaste for the eating of meat:

> It is not right that a man should make his stomach the grave of animals… Were it not for the thought of the difficulty of sustenance I would prohibit men from eating animals. The reason why I do not altogether abandon it myself is that many others might willingly forego it likewise, and be thus cast into despondency.

It was not only the Hindus who were encouraged in their rituals and practices, for the Parsees 'proclaimed the religion of Zardusht as the true